

OSU SCHOOL OF ENTREPRENEURSHIP · EEE 2023 · OCTOBER 1, 2026

My one-year **crash course** in entrepreneurship

3 vibe-coded apps, service offers galore, and the business hiding in plain sight.



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Shimmer Labs & Techie Grandkid · Stillwater

shimmerlabs.co



Hi, I'm **Logan Shimmer**.

2009	OSU engineering. The nerd who liked people too much to only talk to computers.
15 years	Silicon Valley, as the employee, using AI the whole way: • Manufacturing: AI inspecting widgets on the line for quality • Marketing: the right message, to the right person, at the right time • The power grid: cutting home energy costs, absorbing electric cars
2025	Moved home. Started Shimmer Labs.
Today	Two businesses. One I kept pushing for a year. One that showed up on its own.

That was the résumé. **Now the part they don't put on one.**

I didn't study this. I studied engineering.

Two businesses, a lot of mistakes, and a lot of people patient enough to help. **Some of this is going to make you cringe. Good. That way you don't have to live through it yourself.**

Shimmer Labs

The one I planned. Business operations for local owners.

Techie Grandkid

The one that showed up on its own. In-home tech help for retirees.

The help I did get: Small Business University · Google Community AI Fellowship · CoWorkIT Stillwater · every owner who let me ask dumb questions

Quit the job. Sat down. **What do I actually have?**



Everything I tried, **to see what would stick.**

FIRST

Vibe coding

Learning the new tools. **Couldn't believe what I could build.** And AI kept telling me every idea was worth a million dollars. More on that in a minute.

THEN

Subcontracting

A friend's shop couldn't do the technical stuff. I could. **He unlocked business he'd been turning away.**

THEN

Integrations

A very technical guy built an API for podcast transcripts. Nerd speak. **I got it into the marketplaces where actual users could find it.**

ALSO

Teaching

Wrote and taught an AI course for OSU. **Same theme every time: explain the tech to people who don't speak it.**

All of it fit the whiteboard. **None of it was a business yet.**

I built three. **AI said each one would make me rich.**

EventSnag

Screenshot a flyer, it lands on your calendar.

To get users I'd have to **launch city by city**, like Eventbrite did. One town at a time, forever.

0 paying users

FlowMint

Reads a Shopify store, writes the email flows.

A partner was going to sell it through his network. He kept polishing, never launched, then **tried to rewrite our deal**. Hard lesson.

0 paying users

Paidly

Reads a freelancer's contract, writes the invoice.

The tool I wanted. I still use it. I **never figured out how to reach the freelancers who'd want it too**.

0 paying users

Each one worked. **I built all three before asking a single person if they wanted it.**

Dump thousands into ads, **or admit I skipped a step?**

OPTION A

Advertising. Feels like a casino to me. Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok will happily take the money. **I'm not a video producer, and I don't know what makes people click.** Another few months and a few thousand dollars to find out if anyone cares.

WHAT I'D DO NOW

Start with the people who have the problem. Then build. Sorry to everyone who'd rather not talk to humans. It is literally the most important part, and we'll keep coming back to it.

TEXTED TO ME BY FRIENDS WHO VIBE-CODE TOO

Turns out everyone's in the same trap. **"You built it. Nobody came. We can fix that."**



Six in two weeks. Same pitch, same customer: someone who never asked anyone. **Flashy and emotional should trip your alarm, not your wallet.**

YOU'VE BEEN SOLD THIS BEFORE

The pitch fits your pain exactly. **That's the tell.**



The photo on the menu.

"87 paying users by week three. \$0 on ads."



The burger in the bag.

Review sites flag them for buying 5-star ratings. Google flags the tactics as spam.

Too good to be true, **because it is.** These exist because thousands of us built the app before talking to a human.

AI is a **fake best friend**. Every idea you have is gold.

REAL EMAIL, APRIL 2026, TWICE

"I came across your Chrome extension and I was impressed by what you're building. I've been working with extension owners to help them get more real users..."

A stranger, selling me users for an app nobody asked for. The Instagram ads say the same thing: pay us, we'll find your beta testers.

The chatbot never once said **"who is this for?"**

It's built to keep you typing. **Same playbook as social media.**

I'd have spent **a couple grand on ads** just to find out if anyone cared.

Ten humans at a bar would have told me **for free.**

Brainstorm with the bot. **Validate with a person who'd have to pay.**

Stop. **Go talk to a person** and watch their face.

Not a survey. Not a chatbot. A human who'd have to pay. Their reaction in the first three seconds is worth more than three apps. **I wish I had just done that.**

The apps flopped. So I went back to the whiteboard **and started talking.**

WHERE

Run clubs. Stone Cloud. Bike meetups.

Same line from every owner: **"I know I should be using AI. I just don't know how."**

CRINGE

FIRST PITCH

"Your new AI employee."

Did a whole lunch-and-learn on it. The vibe did not land. **But one owner bit, fast. Still a client. Still a friend. Sweat Yoga & Fitness.**

WHAT STUCK

A nerd in your back pocket.

Owners already pay a fractional accountant. A lawyer on retainer. **Position it as the new IT guy, essential, and price it like one.**

THE MODEL TODAY

Snapshot → Assessment → Monthly.

Snapshot	Free
Assessment	\$1,500
Monthly	\$2,000

A few clients. Covers costs and dog treats, not Hawaii. **Early, in a small town, and working.**

The research moved from a chatbot that wants to please me **to customers who pay me.**

“I’m not trying to sell you anything. I’m trying to figure out what I sell.”

WHAT I DID

- Networking through SBU and the Chamber, every week
- Free work for friends and family. **Not a mistake. Research.**
- Said the pitch out loud a hundred times until it stopped sounding like a pitch
- Taught the AI + Marketing course at Small Business University



WHAT CAME BACK

- Invitations to speak: AI fraud, online safety, the Chamber, the Realtors
- **Credibility, trust, exposure.** Conversations started happening to me
- The elevator pitch wrote itself
- Customers who want lower costs and more done with less, **and they're the ones paying now**

Talk to your customers. **Not to AI.**



So that's humming along. Now a completely different story.

Techie Grandkid

Another Main Street business. This one I didn't plan at all. It started with a wood carving and a thrift store.

I was volunteering at a thrift store. The average volunteer was 70.

WEEK 1

"Can you help with my phone?"

Sure. Two minutes.



WEEK 3

"My smart TV's broken. Do you make house calls?"

I guess I do now.



WEEK 4

They hand me wads of twenties.

I never asked. I couldn't leave without it.



WEEK 5

"Can I share your number?"

That means I need a flyer. Which means I need a price.

A year of planning one business. The real one walked up and asked for help.



IN-HOME TECH HELP

Techie Grandkid

The grandkid who's actually good with this stuff.

Phone giving you fits? Wi-Fi down? TV won't behave?
Give me a call. I'll come to you, get it working, and
show you how, with no rushing and no fancy words.

WHAT I CAN HELP WITH

Phones & tablets • Computers & email • Wi-Fi
TVs & streaming • Smart lights • Patient lessons

No question is too small. I'll never make you feel silly.

\$80 a visit first hour included

More time is \$40 per half hour. Need a part? I'll grab it for
a \$30 trip charge plus whatever the part costs.

Call or text Logan

(405) 880-6674

Cash, Venmo, or check, whatever's easiest for you.

I'm a Stillwater neighbor and an OSU grad.

I'll treat you the way I'd want folks treating my own grandparents.

I will never call out of the blue asking for passwords or money.

One flyer. Zero ads, ever.

“\$60 a visit. Would anyone actually pay this?” They texted it to their friends. Now it's \$80 and they still do.

One regular, Sally, sends more referrals than anyone. She talked me into an **Apple Watch class**, then filled the room herself.

Compare: three apps, a waitlist, a Chrome Web Store listing, **zero paying users**.

Sell it before you build it. **A flyer is a business plan you can hand to someone.**

"I'll work in tech, I don't need people skills." Watch this.

A networking event

"What's your day job?" I gave the Shimmer pitch. Then mentioned nights and weekends.



A home-care owner

"I need to introduce you to someone."



Four senior communities

Primrose, Golden Oaks, Legacy Village, Stillwater Medical. In one week.



A sponsored talk

"Come teach our residents to stay safe online. We'll sponsor it." Oct 16.

My next guess: banks might sponsor it too, since fraud costs them. Haven't tested that yet. What I do know: every one of those rooms was full of my customers, and **not one dollar of advertising got me there. All of it was a conversation.**

The tech is the product. **The relationships are the distribution.**

The bar test. Same guy, two pitches.

Shimmer Labs

"I help local businesses automate the stuff they hate with AI."

20%

get it and get excited

The rest hear **"AI takeover"** and change the subject.

Techie Grandkid

"I go to older folks' houses and fix their phone and Wi-Fi."

90%

"Oh my gosh, my mom needs you"

Everyone knows someone. **It's an everyday problem they can see.**

If you can't explain it to a stranger at Stone Cloud, **your customer can't explain it to their friend either.**

I built EventSnag for me. Techie Grandkid found people who aren't me.

EventSnag's customer

Someone new to town, like me. Screenshots of flyers, wants them on a calendar, wants to text a friend.

- I built every feature I wanted
- Turns out that's a very small club
- And it doesn't have much money

Techie Grandkid's customer

Looks nothing like me. Retired, offline, frustrated.

- **Money.** They write checks without blinking.
- **Need.** A real, daily, annoying problem.
- **Enthusiasm.** So grateful they text their friends about it.
- **Overlooked.** Everyone my age says "just make an app." They don't use apps.

Your customer probably doesn't look like you. **Go find who's being ignored.**



Pick the customer who **gives you energy.**

Do I love fixing my own parents' Wi-Fi? No. **Weird power dynamic. I get impatient.** So I assumed I'd hate this.

The lady down the street? **Totally different.** She's grateful, she's got stories, the job's done in twenty minutes and we talk for forty.

A lot of them live alone. **The Wi-Fi was never the whole job.** That's why they text their friends about me.

If your customers drain you, you'll quit. **If they fill you up, you'll overlook them for a year.**

The best businesses are **niche and boring.**

WHAT YOU WANT TO BUILD

Something cool, new, and radical.

- An app. For everyone. Especially people your age.
- Nobody's done it before, which feels like proof.
- Hard to explain, harder to sell, hardest to get anyone to pay for.

WHAT ACTUALLY PAYS

A small group with a real problem nobody bothers to solve.

- **Narrow:** retirees in one town who can't work their phone.
- **Obvious:** everyone knows someone with the problem.
- **Unglamorous:** so nobody with a startup hoodie is competing for it.
- **Paid:** they hand you cash before you leave.

Boring is a moat. **Nobody fights you for the job nobody wants.**

No business model yet. Just experiments I'm running.

IS IT REPEATABLE?

I'll know when I can say "I have half-days booked."

First test: a sign-up sheet at one senior community, residents paying per visit. **If that fills twice, there's a pattern.** If it doesn't, I learned something cheap.

WHERE DOES IT GROW?

Wherever my customer already is.

- Senior living communities
- At-home care agencies
- The people already helping them: insurance navigators, the folks who drive them to appointments
- Referrals from all of the above

Not a TikTok channel. **They aren't there.**

WHAT I WRITE DOWN

Every interaction is data.

Who paid, who flinched at the price, who called back, who asked "is this email real?" after the job. **Throw it at the wall, read what sticks.** That's the model, for now.

You'll cover business models and growth later this semester. **Watch for the part where the plan has to survive the customer.**

What I'd tell **freshman me.**

- 1 Talk to people, not just the bot.** The bot loves every idea. A stranger who'd have to pay doesn't.
- 2 The customer with money and a need probably doesn't look like you.** Go find who's being overlooked.
- 3 Run three-month experiments.** Customer count or reaction tells you if it's working. The clock keeps you from changing course every week, and gives you enough data to decide.
- 4 The hardest part is feeling alone. Find your people.** Customers should give you energy, and so should your peers. The Chamber and the coworking space are where I get mine.
- 5 Relationships are the distribution.** Even for a tech business. Especially for a tech business.

Ask me anything. **Even if it's cringe.**

Happy to continue the conversation. Free, walk-in. Bring the idea, we'll run the bar test on it. **Questions welcome.**

AI Office Hours
Tue & Thu, 2–3 PM
WorkIT Stillwater, 901 S. Main

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IF YOU'RE STUCK, STEAL ONE

Who in your life has a problem they'd pay to make go away?

What would you charge? Say it out loud.

Who's the first stranger you'd pitch it to?